also an official partner for the global campaigns of the World Federation for Mental Health, which founded the World Mental Health Day in 1992. "Today, YMH has one of the largest student networks for mental health, with volunteers from over 100 campuses. The aim is to encourage young people to freely express themselves, reduce stigma and seek support for their well-being," says Sanwal.

For most others—and they form a much larger chunk of India's young population—help may simply be out of bounds. Juhi Sharma, 33, understood this while working with children from some of the most marginalised sections of society, from children living in urban slums to those who have been raised in brothels or shelter homes.

On an average, a single, hour-long session with a therapist or a psychiatrist in India can cost anywhere from Rs 1,000 to Rs 5,000 in a private setting. India has laws like the Mental Health Care Act to provide relief, but accessing treatment remains a challenge on the ground. The Live Love Laugh study also underlines that as many as 55 per cent of the respondents faced difficulties in accessing mental health treatment due to socio-economic factors. "Depression, anxiety, substance abuse—for marginalised sections, there is virtually no support for trauma," says Sharma. She started Emotions Matter, an organisation that works to spread awareness and help marginalised sections access mental health support, after a volunteering experience at a shelter home in Delhi in 2012. "We are sitting on a ticking bomb.... Mental health is paramount for a dignified life—it should be *roti, kapda, makaan* and mental health. Everyone should have a path to resolve trauma," she says.

It's a problem youth from even privileged backgrounds sometimes face, despite rising awareness. "Young people, even if they're ready to fight stereotypes and seek support, largely depend on adults for finances. If their parents don't believe in mental health support, how will they get the money to afford therapy?" says Sanwal.

Having counsellors at institutes is one way to make treatment both affordable and accessible. But until the stigma around mental health is eradicated, no real transformation can begin. And in that, shared experiences can play a huge role. Jaggi, whose organisation encourages people to do exactly that, says, "We started with just five stories, and today, we have covered over 5,000 stories that have reached 50 million people, all organically. Storytelling is not only relatable, but when people speak out, it is a cathartic moment for them, and it inspires others to do the same." The organisation receives around 500 emails a month from youngsters, about how a story encouraged them to talk about their own experience. Interestingly, many are from men. "For men, voicing their emotions is discouraged from a very young age. So, a platform that lets them express themselves freely is a step forward," says Jaggi.



"PEOPLE ARE MORE INDIVIDUALISTIC AND ISOLATED AND THERE IS **SIGNIFICANTLY MORE** PRESSURE FROM THE ENVIRONMENT TODAY"

DR PUROITREE MAJUMDAR
Clinical psychologist, Bengaluru

CHALLENGES GALORE

Over the years, such efforts have revealed both what youth want and the challenges mental health support groups face in helping them. In 2016, It's Ok to Talk, a project started by Sangath, a non-profit organisation that promotes mental wellness, held an offline event in Delhi. When they realised that using the term 'mental health' in the project title repelled a few, they started using words like 'stress', 'feelings', or 'emotions'. "We have a long way to go before 'mental health' stops being associated with 'mad' people," says Sweta Pal, project director at It's Ok to Talk. Privacy, too, emerged as a significant factor. "This generation does not feel comfortable if someone else is going to know about their experience. In fact, many youth prefer to be anonymous, so our website lets people share their story anonymously," says Pal. YourDost, too, sees maximum traffic between 9 pm and 3 am, when most youth are alone.

Often, families object to their children being termed 'mentally unwell' and threaten counsellors, or are wary of getting medication for the fear of their child getting addicted to antidepressants. In some cases, it can take weeks for a person to open up, and the investment by the counsellor has to sustain through this period to build trust. It's particularly difficult to help youth from underprivileged backgrounds when both public officials and families insist that education and jobs must be the focus, not trauma. "People still don't understand the work I do," says Sharma. "Sometimes, I'm judged by the scale of my work. I tell them scale is not the point, quality is. If I helped save just 15 lives, those 15 lives really mattered to me." It is also heartening when someone she has helped pays it forward, in any way possible. Like Kunal Kumar, who grew up at a brothel in Delhi. Counselled by Sharma for his mental trauma, the 22-year-old went on to start Maan Foundation, an organisation that works for the rights and dignity of sex workers. One youth saved can save an entire future. ■